That was easier said than done. Shimla has only a small airfield, that too at Jubbarhatti, 22 km away, suitable only for small propeller aircraft, such as the IAF Dornier aircraft. This would take us to Delhi, about an hour's flying time, before changing over to an Avro for another two to three hours in the air, depending on the final destination, plus refuelling halts, if any. This itself would take up a full day either way. Add to that the two to three days visiting that institution meant that for each visit, we would be out of Shimla for nearly an entire week. The first time we flew in the Avro, the CO of the squadron told me that very soon they would be getting modern aircraft, the C-295 to replace the vintage Avro. That did not happen as the first C-295 was inducted into the IAF only in October 2023, which just shows how long and convoluted the acquisition process is. A couple of days in Shimla to take stock of the HQ and pass instructions and then it was off again. These visits were not only to the training establishments but also to the various Commands for their war games and to Delhi for conferences. I don't think I ever spent more than a week at a stretch at Shimla. During these visits, I would go around the various locations where the training was in progress, to see whether the curriculum was contemporary, using the latest training aids and methodologies and was in keeping with our operational philosophy.

Obviously, what was applicable for a PCTA, which trains cadets, would not necessarily be applicable for the AWC, which trains officers. Similarly, there would be differences in the curriculum of the Infantry School vis-à-vis the Armoured or Artillery School. Or for that matter, in the training methodology between the EME School, which imparts technical training, as compared to the CIJW School, which is purely a tactical course. This called for an in-depth knowledge of each of the branches of the Army, what roles they were expected to fulfil

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